



THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

May 7, 2024

The Reverend Rachel Cooley Shawler
San Diego, California

Dear Reverend Shawler,

Thank you for writing to me about the war between Israel and Hamas.

On October 7, more than 1,300 innocent civilians were murdered in Israel—including American citizens—at the hands of the terrorist organization Hamas. We must always condemn terrorism when we see it. There is no justification for it—no excuse.

But Hamas does not represent the Palestinian people. It does not stand for the dignity of Palestinians. We mourn the many innocent Palestinians who have been killed. Many thousands of families in Gaza are suffering an escalating humanitarian crisis.

That is why my Administration is working closely with partners to ensure that life-saving assistance—including food, water, and medicine—can urgently reach innocent Palestinians in Gaza. The United States stands unequivocally for the protection of civilians during conflict, and we will do everything possible to prevent the conflict from spreading across the region. As I have emphasized both publicly and with Israel's leadership, all countries must uphold international humanitarian law. I will continue to work steadfastly with partners to pursue peace and a two-state solution so that the Israeli and the Palestinian people can both enjoy equal measures of security and dignity.

Here at home, I have directed my team to identify, prevent, and disrupt any domestic threats that could emerge against Muslim, Arab, Palestinian, Jewish, or any other communities. There is no place for hate in America. Not against Muslims. Not against Arabs. Not against Palestinians. Not against Jews. Not against anybody.

Under my Administration, the United States will continue to combat Islamophobia, antisemitism, and all forms of hate as we uphold the right of Americans to express themselves. And we will continue to hold in our hearts all the families across our country and around the world who are mourning the loss of a loved one—a piece of their soul—to this tragedy.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Joe Biden", written over a diagonal line.